

The U.S. Strategy for AI Leadership: A Closer Look at the 2025 America's AI Action Plan

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The United States has issued a national strategy to secure global leadership in artificial intelligence: *Winning the Race: America's AI Action Plan (July 2025)*. The plan is structured around three pillars:

1. Accelerating AI innovation
2. Building American AI infrastructure
3. Leading in international AI diplomacy and security

One standout feature of the Action Plan is that it provides open source AI with unprecedented visibility in federal strategy. Let's unpack the key components and what they mean.

Pillar I: Accelerating AI Innovation

The US government aims to remove regulatory friction, encourage private sector innovation, and ensure that AI systems reflect core "American values", such as freedom of speech and diversity of viewpoints. Key elements of this pillar include the following priorities:

- A strong endorsement of open source and open weight AI models, framing them as essential for innovation, strategic independence, and reducing reliance on closed, proprietary systems. (Great wins for open source! I cover this in more detail in a later section.)
- Support for academic access to models, training data, and compute, recognizing the role of universities in advancing AI research.
- New standards to reduce bias in AI procurement, to ensure that federally used models are trustworthy and aligned with constitutional values.

Pillar II: Building American AI Infrastructure

The second pillar of the Action Plan focuses on removing bureaucratic hurdles and accelerating the development of physical and digital infrastructure to support the growth of AI. The Action Plan calls explicitly for the following priorities:

- Restoring U.S. leadership in semiconductor manufacturing.
- Reforming permitting systems for data centers and energy infrastructure.
- Building secure, high-performance compute environments for defense and intelligence use.
- Training a skilled workforce through apprenticeships, vocational education, and industry partnerships to meet the demands of AI-related infrastructure roles.

Pillar III: International AI Diplomacy and Security

The third pillar of the Action Plan connects AI leadership directly to foreign policy and national security. The plan emphasizes the following priorities:

- Exporting the full U.S. AI stack (hardware, models, standards) to allies, ensuring they adopt American technology rather than turn to geopolitical rivals.
- Blocking adversaries from accessing advanced compute and chips, and strengthening enforcement of export controls.
- Countering China's influence in international AI standards bodies.
- Evaluating national security risks of frontier AI models, including potential misuse in biological or cyber domains.

The core strategy of the Action Plan positions AI as a technological priority and a geopolitical advantage.

Open Source and Open Weight AI: A Strategic Priority

One of the most significant aspects of the plan (as someone who's been involved in open source for 30+ years) is its treatment of open source AI and open weights as a central tool in America's AI strategy.

Key highlights from the Action Plan include:

- Open models give startups and researchers freedom to build, without being tied to closed platforms or restrictive licensing.
- Sensitive data in government and enterprise contexts often can't be shared with proprietary vendors, while open models offer flexibility.

- Academic research depends on open weights and training datasets to validate results and advance the field.
- American-led open models can become global reference points, shaping norms and standards in AI use worldwide.

Policy Moves

The US government lays out several policy moves in support of this Action Plan:

- Expand access to compute by developing market mechanisms (like spot and forward contracts) that make high-end GPU access more affordable and flexible for smaller players (startups, academia).
- Strengthen the NAIRR pilot (National AI Research Resource) by partnering with private sector providers to offer researchers access to models, data, and compute.
- Sustain open access over the long term through lean NAIRR operations.
- Support small and medium-sized enterprises by creating targeted initiatives to help them adopt open models.
- Publish a revised National AI R&D Strategy with a clear emphasis on open science, open data, and open infrastructure.

The Role of Open Datasets

The plan also expands support for open datasets:

- Researchers funded by the federal government may be required to publish non-sensitive datasets used in training.
- Agencies will promote public access to high-quality, AI-ready data, particularly for science and engineering domains.
- A large-scale genome sequencing effort on federal lands is proposed to create open biological datasets for future foundation models in biotech.

The Message is Clear

Open source AI is now a core part of the U.S. national strategy for innovation, resilience, and global influence.

However, the real infrastructure for open source AI is already being built elsewhere.

The **PyTorch Foundation** is one example. It provides a neutral governance home for one of the most widely used frameworks in AI. Through community input and industry collaboration, it ensures PyTorch remains open, stable, and responsive to the needs of developers.

The **LF AI & Data Foundation** plays a similar role, hosting and nurturing over 70 open source AI and data projects, offering legal clarity, interoperability guidance, technical infrastructure support, and a sustainable ecosystem model.

The **Open Source Initiative (OSI)** is defining what “open source AI” actually means. Without clear guidance on model weights, training data, and usage rights, the term “open” risks becoming meaningless or misleading. The OSI’s effort provides the concept with a legal and ethical foundation.

In addition, the emergence of licenses like OpenMDW indicates that the legal infrastructure is catching up. It offers permissive yet precise terms for sharing and building on model weights, a key requirement for safe and widespread adoption of open models (as also pointed out in the Action Plan).

Final Thoughts

If this Action Plan moves from paper to execution, the next three to five years could redefine how AI is built, deployed, and governed in the US and globally.

We could see the emergence of a genuinely open, American-led AI ecosystem.

- Open weight models, backed by federal infrastructure and funding, would become the default in research labs, startups, and even government services.
- Access to compute (previously a privilege of a few hyperscalers) could be unlocked through public-private markets that resemble energy or telecom sectors.
- Small companies, R&D labs, universities, and public institutions would no longer be priced out of frontier innovation.
- The NAIRR pilot could mature into a national backbone for AI research, connecting universities, federal agencies, and commercial partners through shared data, computing resources, and tools.
- Instead of silos, we’d have a federated, distributed innovation network that is fast-moving, accountable, and open by design.
- Standards bodies and international allies may begin adopting US-backed open models that embody interoperable values: freedom to audit, modify, and repurpose. That’s strategic leverage that would make it harder for closed AI systems to become global defaults.
- Domestically, open source AI would be embedded in how the government runs: in defense systems, in infrastructure resilience, in regulatory decision-making.
- Government procurement pipelines would treat open source as a first-class option.

- Public trust in AI systems would grow through verifiable transparency and clear accountability.
- Foundations like the PyTorch Foundation, LF AI & Data, and the OSI would form the civic infrastructure of AI. Their governance models, licensing frameworks, and community norms would evolve from “best practice” to “global baseline”.

This vision is ambitious, but it could also be achievable. The question is whether this administration and those that follow can execute on that vision and remain focused on treating open source as a strategic pillar of national leadership.

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- *Reflections on the Open Source AI Definition: Mapping to the Model Openness Framework*
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About the Author

Dr. Ibrahim Haddad leads the Infotainment Engineering Group at Volvo Cars. He previously served as Vice President of Strategic Programs (AI) at the Linux Foundation, where he was the Executive Director of LF AI & Data and the Founding Executive Director of the PyTorch Foundation. Previously, Dr. Haddad served as Vice President of R&D and a Distinguished Engineer at Samsung Research. His career spans technical and portfolio leadership roles at Ericsson Research, the Open Source Development Labs, Motorola, Palm, and Hewlett-Packard. ([LinkedIn](#) - [Website](#))